

Photo quality

If you are expecting smartphone-level sharpness, you are looking at the wrong product. The Instax Mini 13 does not aim for perfect photos. It aims for photos with feeling.

Without getting into the technical nitty-gritty, just know that the instant prints have that soft, nostalgic look people love. Colours come out vibrant, especially in brighter environments. Background lights, neon signs, and party scenes can look fantastic on Instax film. There is a warmth to these photos that digital images don't have.

My colleague especially liked how selfies looked. Faces were bright, skin tones looked pleasant, and the final print had that retro vibe many people actively chase with filters on Instagram.

That said, there are limitations.

In some scenes, the flash can be a bit strong, which may make faces look brighter than expected. Low-light shots can also be softer or less detailed. Fine textures and details are not this camera's strength.

But here is the thing: none of that feels like a dealbreaker. Some of those quirks are part of the appeal. Slight softness, unexpected lighting, imperfect framing, these are the details that make each print feel unique.

Learning to frame

If you are coming from a smartphone, the biggest adjustment is the viewfinder. What you see while framing is not always exactly what ends up on the final print. It takes a little practice.

My colleague mentioned that some shots were slightly off-centre at first, and that is a normal part of using cameras like this. Naturally, after getting a few packs of film, you will eventually learn how to compose better and leave a bit of room around your subject.

However, selfies are easier thanks to the close-up mode and mirror on the front, though fitting three or four people into one frame can be tricky. This works



best for one or two people, especially at an arm's length.

Apart from this, the new Close-up mode is another useful feature to have. Twist the lens once, and you are ready for closer selfies or tighter portraits. Again, quite handy for casual close-up selfies or photos of small objects.

There is also a built-in self-timer, and this might be one of the best additions for this generation. As the name suggests, you set the timer, place the camera down, and everyone gets into the frame. My colleague told me how she used the self-timer for a group shot because nobody wanted to be left out holding the camera.

Now, with everything out of the way, let's get to the part that no one should ignore about the Instax Mini 13.

The Film Cost

The Instax Mini 13 camera itself may seem reasonably priced at first,

especially if you compare it with smartphone cameras or premium cameras. But the long-term cost comes from regularly buying film. And film is not cheap.

And because of this recurring cost, it totally changes how you use the camera. You do not fire off ten shots of the same pose. You think first. You wait for the right moment. You make each click count.

For many Gen Z buyers who love the instant camera trend, the cost of film can be the biggest barrier for entry. No doubt, the camera is very fun, but owning one properly means budgeting for film packs again and again.

So yes, the initial price may look manageable, but the real spend grows over time. Still, I would not call that a reason to avoid it. It just means you should know what you are signing up for.

Final verdict

The Fujifilm Instax Mini 13 is not the most practical camera you can buy. Your phone is cheaper to run, sharper, faster, and more convenient in almost every way.

But that is also precisely why this camera exists.

The Instax Mini 13 turns photography into something deliberate again. You click less, care more, and end up with something physical you can hold, gift, stick on a wall, or keep in a drawer for years. Trust me, that feeling is hard to replicate with photos lost somewhere in cloud storage.

Yes, film is expensive. Yes, results depend on lighting. Yes, it takes a bit of practice. But the joy this little camera brings is real.

Long story short, if you want perfect photos, use your phone, but if you want memories that feel special, the Instax Mini 13 is a lovely thing to own. **D**

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